

India-China border framework leaves rifts intact

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【メール原文】

An eight-point border framework will ease near-term tensions, but deep mutual distrust makes any substantive resolution of the underlying dispute unlikely.

Quick take

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Underlying distrust will limit impact of India-China border announcement

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What Happened

India and China announced they had agreed to an eight-point framework to advance negotiations to resolve their long-standing border dispute, with the first goal being to hold working group meetings to hammer out the terms of reference. The announcement was preceded by a military standoff between the two armies along the disputed border in the eastern Himalayas.

Our Take

The announcement will ease bilateral tensions without offering a substantive resolution of the border problem. Never friendly, relations between India and China have been especially strained since a 2020 border clash that saw casualties on both sides. While a two-year normalization process has seen direct flights resume and some visa restrictions eased, the two militaries remain deployed in the forward positions they had taken in 2020. Beijing has pushed for a so-called early harvest agreement designed to demarcate the military border in the eastern Himalayas. While short of a formally recognized border, it would reduce the likelihood of an accidental military clash. India sees a piecemeal border agreement as being inimical to its territorial claims. Yet the past few weeks have seen increased, though non-kinetic, Chinese military action along the border, culminating in a standoff earlier this month in the eastern Himalayas.

The announcement means India has agreed to discuss the terms of reference for a path toward an early harvest agreement. However, it is unlikely that this will result in any tangible success over the next several months. Announced army-to-army hotlines will help lower tensions, but the degree of distrust between the two makes a return to pre-2020 military deployments very unlikely. Nonetheless, the presence of border negotiations is likely to mean a quieter frontier for the next year.

There will only be a slight easing of mutual weaponization of trade and investment barriers. The India-China rivalry has progressively shifted to aggressive supply chain policies, especially by China. After initially complaining about Indian restrictions on Chinese FDI, Beijing has increasingly restricted the flow of Chinese technicians to India, imposed export controls on permanent magnets and certain electronic components, and, most recently, denied visas to Indian engineers and executives in sensitive economic sectors. India recently eased FDI rules for Chinese investment, but largely to assist Western investors (see: [Relations with China will remain hostile despite eased FDI restrictions](#) , 20 March 2026).

The border developments are unlikely to have a meaningful impact on these policies. India has raised these issues with China, seeking greater transparency and clarity on export control rules affecting Indian firms, but with minimal success. Since both sides began imposing economic restrictions on each other in 2020, economic policy has moved largely independently of the situation on the border. The new talks will, at best, help keep these policies from getting worse.

Border negotiations have a tangential effect on Chinese attendance at the BRICS summit. While there has been speculation that the border standoff fits a pattern of such incidents in the run-up to a visit by President Xi Jinping to India, officials in New Delhi doubt this is the case. Xi's second visit to India in 2019, for example, was not preceded by a clash.

The Chinese president holding back his formal acceptance to attend the BRICS summit on 12-13 September is more about an older pattern of leaders from both countries slow-rolling acceptance to participate in each other's multilateral events. Prime Minister Narendra Modi delayed accepting his invitation to the BRICS summit in Xiamen, China, in 2017 to pressure Beijing to back down from a larger military standoff over the Doklam plateau. With China hosting next year's BRICS summit—and quorum rules requiring every member's leader to attend—Xi was always unlikely to skip, if only to avoid handing Modi grounds to do the same in return.

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